

Postmodernism

Structuralism, post-structuralism, post-modernism

Structuralism – single and stable meaning, objective reality, epistemology

Post-structuralism: meaning is not stable, dependent on interpretation, multiple truths and meanings, reality is socially constructed, no universal truth.

Post-modernism: after modernity, many movements including post-structuralism. May suggest post-modern methods of resistance or nihilism.

Modernism – grand narratives, truth through science and investigation, mass media and unified systems of control

Post-modernism – breakdown of this (crisis, wars, fall of Communism, technology, media)

Postmodern styles

In architecture, cinema, television, video games

Lyotard

Jean-François Lyotard's *The Postmodern Condition* (1979) argues that postmodernity is defined by a growing disbelief in “grand narratives”—the big stories that once claimed to explain and justify knowledge, progress, and social order (such as Enlightenment rationality, Marxism, or Christianity).

Lyotard on post-modernism

Postmodernity is a condition in which knowledge is fragmented, instrumentalised, and no longer justified by universal truths, but by efficiency, usefulness, and local rules.

Lyotard on media

For Lyotard, postmodernity is marked by the breakdown of unified truth. Media play a central role in this.

Media no longer transmit a shared worldview. Instead, they circulate discrete, competing messages. No single media narrative can claim authority over others

Media become part of a landscape of plural language games, not a source of consensus. Performativity governs media

Baudrillard

Sign value

Shift from Marxist conception of value (use / exchange) to sign value – the signification implied in the transaction ‘The sign object is neither given nor exchanged: it is appropriated, withheld and manipulated by individual subjects as a sign, that is as a coded difference’ (Simulacra and Simulation).

Hypermarket

Modern shopping centre based in the heart of a community, now based in its own area, now out of the city creates its own spatial / temporal distortions like a satellite having gravitational pull. Generates new geographical and experiential space (and new modes of living). Consumers who pass through this space are screened and tested, surveilled and noted in terms of their consumption. Yet behaviour is playful and whimsical.

Hyperreality

In third order simulation the hyperreal proceeds the real but this does not mean that there’s a blurring of these rather the reversal becomes irrelevant. Hyperreal is measured by performativity, how well does it operate.

Disneyland

Disneyland – We tend to think of this as a fantasy representation, exaggeration of features of reality, based on the work of Walt Disney, films and cartoons. Disneyland as a third order simulation – the hyperreal. Measured in terms of performativity, how well does it operate, like a real city Prisons – hide the fact that we are all incarcerated in society. Disneyland exists to conceal the fact that it is the real America Operates like a deterrence machine to conceal the fact that the real is no longer real.

‘Disneyland is presented as imaginary in order to make us believe that the rest is real, when in fact all of Los Angeles and the America surrounding it are no longer real, but of the order of the hyperreal and simulation’

Political scandals

Watergate (political scandal) – Baudrillard argues that it is not a scandal but exists as the hyperreal to covers up that Government / capitalism itself is corrupt and a scandal – an aberration. Attempts dissimulation ‘...an imaginary effect, like Disneyland, concealing that reality no more exists outside than inside the bounds of an artificial parameter’

Simulation – to feign / pretend (eg pretending one is sick by making oneself sick) – gap between the two collapses. Dissimulation – reveal the pretence. Political scandal is a pretence that government is not scandalous. Baudrillard argues that it’s not possible to dissimulate gives the example of simulating an armed robbery (not possible as to simulate would be to conduct an armed robbery).

Gulf war did not take place

Gulf war was overwhelming strength (like a pre-programmed war), using US technology and broadcast ‘live’ The war was a postmodern act to see if war was possible in the current age. Shrinking of perspective (audience were there) and imagery so not possible to say if it happened or not.

Reality TV

Real and represented are identical – they implode into one thing, no perceptual distance. The eye of TV is no longer a panoptic gaze, the gaze is invited and is the ‘test’, ‘YOU are the content’ the end of the panopticon. Media stages reality

Jameson’s critique of post-modernism

Postmodern theory and culture are the primary form of cultural production in Late Capitalism in art, architecture, literature and film. These produce an ahistoricism where texts become styles and history is represented through pastiche. Alternative (utopian) trajectories for a system other than capitalism collapse into mere fads, narratives, or vague fantasies.